

9 Using Commands

9.4.2 open

In Mac OS X's version of Unix, the `open` command is easy enough: `open -a`, like `open -a Chess`. The `-a` flag allows you to specify an application by name, regardless of where it is present on your hard drive if that application is properly installed. You can even specify which file you want to open in some programs by adding a space and then the file's name, like: `open -a Preview Image1.jpg`.

Note

The `-e` flag opens any text file in TextEdit, like: `open -e Diary.txt`. This shortcut saves you from having to specify the TextEdit application itself like in the previous case.

9.4.3 kill

Mac OS X offers no shortage of ways to kill a program that seems to be locked up. You can force quit it, use Process Viewer and end the process, or use `kill` from the terminal.

The `kill` program in Terminal simply force quits a program/process, as though by a remote control. It even works when you telnet or SSH into your Mac over the internet from a remote location. All you have to do is type the `kill` command followed by the ID number of the program you want to terminate.

9.4.4 top

Typing `top` and pressing Enter gives you a handy table that lists every program that's currently running on your Mac, including the obscure background processes you may not even know exist. The `top` display will remain on-screen, automatically updating itself as you work, until you type `q` to quit the program. You also get statistics that tell you how much memory and processing power they're hogging. In this regard, `top` is very similar to Process Viewer found in Utilities

Note

If you type `top -u`, you get a list sorted by CPU usage. If your Mac ever seems to act sluggish, you can check `top -u` to see what's tying things up and kill them.

9.4.5 ps

The `ps` (process status) command is another way to see all the programs running on your Mac, even the usually invisible ones, complete with their process ID numbers.

9.4.6 grep

`grep` filter is a powerful program designed to search data fed to it on a quest